

10.3 Animating With ImageReady

One of the most exciting things about ImageReady is its ability to make GIF animation really easy. At the most basic level, all you need to know to get your first animation out is how to turn layer visibility on and off (we're hoping you've read the previous chapters and know this by now).

Unlike other GIF animation programs, though, ImageReady works closely with the PSD format and image layers to create animated GIFs, so if you've used any of these other programs (such as Paint Shop Pro), it's going to take you a little while to learn it the ImageReady way.

To get past the first few hiccups, here's what you can animate:

- **Layer Visibility**—the simplest animations work on turning layer visibility on and off as the animation moves on. A classic example is blinking text.
- **Layer Position**—moving layers around can create some interesting effects.
- **Layer Opacity**—change this for cool fade in/fade out effects.
- **Layer Blending Modes**.
- **Layer Styles**—these can be added at any time to any frame without upsetting any of the other frames in the animation.

If you're going to change content in the animation—like turning a blue vase into an orange one—you'll have to create a new layer for the orange vase and play with the layer visibility or opacity.

10.3.1 A Flashing Banner

We've hinted more than a little at how animation is as easy as turning a layer on and off: now we'll prove it.

Start with a new image ([Ctrl] + [N]) and choose Web Banner from the Image Size drop-down menu. Use the Text Tool ([T]) to type out whatever you want on the banner. Change the font to Impact for a better... well... impact, and the font colour to red. Or you could just skip formatting the text and move on by just using a large font size.